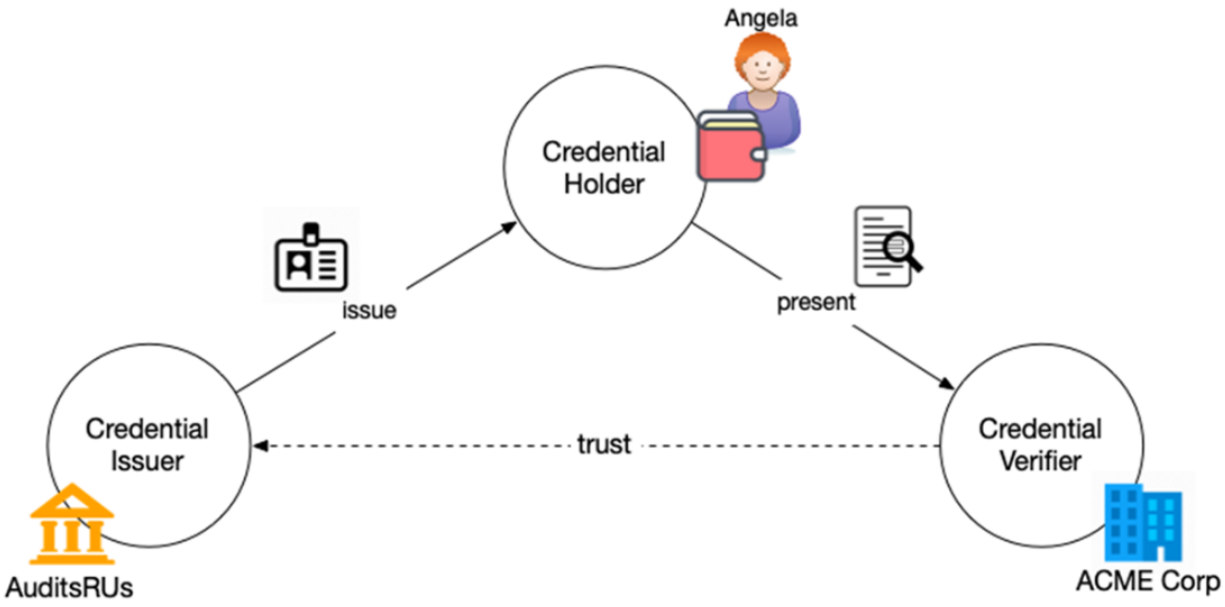


Figure 16.1 The verifiable credential trust triangle. The issuer, AuditsRUs, creates and signs the credential. The holder, Angela, carries and presents it. ACME verifies the signature and uses the data in the credential as context when it evaluates policy.

This approach allows attributes to move across organizational boundaries without the need for synchronization, federation, or prior relationships. Employers, certification bodies, clinics, regulators, suppliers, and manufacturers can all issue credentials that verify facts within their authority. ACME doesn't have to maintain directories for each partner or integrate with each partner's identity system. Cryptography separates the process of transmitting the credential from the act of trusting it. As shown in the figure, the holder does not merely send the credential. Instead, they generate a presentation based on it, which the verifier can validate independently.

Because verifiable credentials present structured claims that can be validated, checked for freshness, and normalized, they integrate naturally into ACME's context model. From the authorization engine's perspective, they are simply another trustworthy signal that accompanies the access request. Once a credential has been verified, the policy engine can assess its contents just as it would evaluate internal attributes, environmental context, or device posture signals.